RSS cadres contrasted Bihar's backwardness with images of Gujarat's prosperity in their door-to-door campaign. Perhaps in a state election where the chief ministership was at stake, Nitish might have been more of a factor. He had, after all, worked hard for the development of one of the most difficult states in the country to govern. His road-building projects in particular had been universally applauded. Patna was a safer city where women could finally walk freely after dark. *'Gujarat chalana aasan hai, Bihar ko sudharna bahut muskhil'* (It is easy to run Gujarat, to improve Bihar is very difficult), he told me once. But the 2014 elections were not a battle about who should rule in Patna but who was best placed to lead India. Modi in 2014 was a declared prime ministerial candidate; Nitish's horizons were limited by his state's boundaries.

'We had three weapons for Bihar,' a BJP strategist told me later. 'Modi as an OBC leader who could lead the nation, upper-caste anger against Nitish for ditching the BJP, and the promise of fast growth and jobs.' The strategy worked. A cross-caste Hindu consolidation was visible across a majority of the state's forty seats. Bihar had been conquered, but an even bigger challenge awaited Modi in neighbouring Uttar Pradesh.

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The road to Delhi leads through Lucknow. Or so we have been led to believe for decades. Between 1947 and 1991, all of India's prime ministers came from the land of Awadh. The one exception was the Mumbai-based Gujarati Morarji Desai, whose ascent as the leader of the Janata Party government in 1977 was fortuitous. Less than two years later, he was replaced by another UP-ite, Chaudhary Charan Singh. Hindi–Hindu–Hindustan had defined the politics of the Jan Sangh and the BJP for years. The only BJP prime minister, Atal Bihari Vajpayee, had been the pride of Lucknow. In a sense, Narendra Modi was fighting history—not only had no sitting chief minister been prime minister, no BJP leader from outside the Indo-Gangetic plain had made it to the top.